EIGHT GOOD REASONS WHY WE NEED ANOTHER INDIA INQUIRY - FOR SUCH A TIME AS THIS[1]

2019-05-12

By Luis Bush

Introduction: At the specific request of three influential Christian leaders from India we embrace their recommendation for another India Inquiry: ***For Such a Time as This***. One of the first challenges in responding to the call to transform our world in the twenty-first century is for God's servants to pursue an approach that will advance God's Kingdom purposes so that His will is done on earth as it is in heaven. This paper is an adaptation of the original seventeen years later.

Today we hear of strongholds of specific regions and nations being shaken and God moving with power in the nations. At his birth a new star appeared in the heavens, which brought the wise men from the East to visit him; the angels of heaven descended and sung Glory to God in the highest.

We are at a kairos moment of history. God is shaking our world as is somewhat reminiscent of the shakings in the heavens, earth, and sea, at the birth of Christ, during his life, and at his death. We too have a sense of destiny as God's people in our generation.

The following basic questions were addressed as we took a three-year journey in the listening mode from 2002 to 2005 in an inquiry in India among many cities and in other nations. They are designed to foster discussion around the primary catalytic impulses leading to understanding how to do God's will as God's people working together on His mission following His mandate of discipling the nations. What has changed since the Inquiry conducted throughout Inida and what needs to be changed between then and now? These are questions to be addressed in an upcoming India Inquiry: ***For Such a Time as This***

Even if we do not have great differential revelations in the last fifteen years, one of the expected outcomes of doing the 2030 Inquiry is that the process itself will catalyze world evangelization and advance God's Kingdom purposes. The focus group approach, with the right kind of questions and, under the right conditions, has proven to be very effective. As the quantitative and qualitative survey is conducted among Christian leaders in hundreds of cities across the world and the insights communicated widely, the assumption is that a missiology can be constructed capable of empowering the global church for an informed participation in world evangelization in the twenty-first century.

The problem the Inquiry seeks to address is threefold: first, the yet-unfinished task of discipling the nations and lack of clarity of what that means; second, the need to make the next phase one in which the worldwide evangelical movement participates fully, including insights offered from the Majority World leaders; and third, the need to define new paradigms of mission.

In addressing the major issues related to a resource-consuming global effort, the first is the justification of the project itself. The first section titled "Why another World Inquiry?" lays out the reasons for this

[1]Bush, Luis K. (2001). *Catalysts of World Evangelization* (2002) Adapted from Ph.D. Dissertation from SWM, Fuller Theological Seminary, Ed. 2006), Centre for Contemporary Christianity, Bangalore, India. Pages 167-191.

endeavor which remain the same at this new season of mission. For the sake of consistency between that inquiry and the upcoming one and to ensure that the basic questions are covered, the other sections of this introductory assessment deal with the fundamental questions of what, where, why, how long, who and what are the limitations?

A. Why another World Inquiry?

There are a number of important reasons why the Inquiry is a priority concern for Christian leaders at the outset of the 2030 decade. These seven reasons range from the timeless encouragement found in the Scriptures to the time-sensitive realities facing the global church at the outset of a new millennium.

1. Because the Conversation Illuminates the Purpose of God

God has used inquiries and research efforts to enhance world evangelization which began when he sent two angels to facilitate the "empty tomb focus group," comprising a few women who had come on the first Easter morning to find an empty tomb. We are told in another gospel who these women were and why they were going to the tomb where Jesus' body was laid.

"Mary Magdalene, Mary the mother of James, and Salome bought spices so that they might go to anoint Jesus' body" (Mk. 16:1). While they were standing at the tomb in amazement when they did not find the body of the Lord "suddenly two men in clothes that gleamed like lightning stood beside them." These were messengers sent from God to act as the group facilitators. They posed the question: "Why do you look for the living among the dead?" (Lk. 24:6). In the course of the discussion it was revealed to the women that he was not there. "He has risen! Remember how He told you, while He was still with you in Galilee: 'The Son of Man must be delivered into the hands of sinful men, be crucified and on the third day be raised again'" (Lk. 24:7).

The women reported to the other followers of Jesus what they had learned. Peter was mobilized to find out for himself. Consequently, the first world evangelization movement was launched out of the inquiry process.

2. Because Focus Group Inquiries are Biblical at Different Seasons

The focus group was a mechanism used deliberately by God. It catalyzed an unprecedented movement of world evangelization. It was this same Peter, about thirty-five years after his running to the Empty Tomb, who wrote about the controlling role of the Holy Spirit in the selection and recording of content for the Scriptures. "Above all, you must understand that no prophecy of Scripture came about by the prophet's own interpretation. For prophecy never had its origin in the will of man, but men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit" (1 Peter 1:21-22). In order to reinforce the significance of the focus group methodology, in relation to evangelism and mission, the incident at the Empty Tomb is immediately followed up in the Lucan account by another focus group inquiry, which could be called the "Emmaus Road Focus Group Inquiry." This time the facilitator of the discussion between the two disciples is none other than the resurrected Lord Jesus Christ himself, though they did not recognize him at first.

Jesus intervened in the discussion with three questions: "What are you discussing together as you walk along? . . . What things?" (Lk. 24:17, 19). This second question caused the disciples to report

on the incident related to the Empty Tomb Focus Group: Some of our women amazed us.

They went to the tomb early this morning but didn't find his body. They came and told us that they had seen a vision of angels, who said he was alive. Then some of our companions went to the tomb and found it just as the women had said, but him they did not see (Lk. 24:22-24).

This response of the two disciples led Jesus to rebuke them and pose his final question. "How foolish you are, and how slow of heart to believe all that the prophets have spoken! Did not the Christ have to suffer these things and then enter his glory?" (Lk. 24:25-26). The follow-up focusses group inquiry resulted in the two remaining disciples turning around and joining the other disciples already assembled in Jerusalem, where Jesus now appeared to all of them to commission them for the task of world evangelization. "Repentance and forgiveness of sins will be preached in his name to all nations, beginning at Jerusalem" (Lk. 24:47).

Coming with an agenda to listen to God's servants is biblical. James writes: "My dear brothers, take note of this: Everyone should be quick to listen" (Jas. 1:19a).

3. Because there is a Need to Hear Intentionally from senior and emerging Christian leaders in India

The emergence of Christian leadership in India, as equal partners in mission, combined with the initiative in world evangelization efforts over the last twenty-five years of the twentieth century in India, demands that their ideas help shape the direction of world evangelization in the twenty-first century in this great nation. It is clear that many wish to do so; the question is how to help catalyze the true reflective inputs and resultant direction based on models within and from outside and a fresh ecclesiology that has emanated from India to the nations beyond.

One of the major trends is the "Shift in geographical and vital center of gravity of the church from the West and North to the East and South" (Woodberry 2000). Out of this new spiritual nerve center, initiative for world mission has grown exponentially. "As Christianity has globalized, indigenous missions have sprung up around the world" (Woodberry 2000). The Christian mission and church leaders from all around the world express their view of what the "Spirit is saying to the Church" at this time. However, more than ever before that expression is coming from Asia, Africa and Latin America and in this case, from India itself.

What kind of a theology of mission will best serve the global Christian mission in India, South Asia and beyond on the future? What fresh theological resources can be brought to bear on this new phase of the Christian mission? It is time to listen to voices from the non-Western world that can help construct a theology capable of empowering the global church for participation in the *missio Dei* (Shenk 2001a:98).

The active participation of Christian leaders from all over the India in shaping twenty-first century world evangelization is crucial for this Inquiry. We pray that information might mesh with relationships of the broader world community to foster increased evangelization, to the end that there can be a significant advance in the Christian Movement over the next quarter century.

4. Because of the Catalytic Nature of the Inquiry Process

Many missiologists agree that it was during the twentieth century when the Christian movement advanced to its greatest extent geographically, among the ethno-linguistic peoples of the earth and in mobilizing cross-cultural missions. Out of the accomplishments and lessons learned from recent history, the inquiry launches a journey in the listening mode that involves a process of advocacy, assessment with anticipation of advance in Kingdom initiatives, and transformation.

The advocacy process is already underway, sharing the inquiry vision with many prototype groups already trialed and plans made for the full geographic coverage and meetings/data collection and summary envisioned. In order to validate the inquiry purpose, objectives, questionnaires, and meetings were held with sample groups and research survey experts over a period of five months leading up to December 31, 2001, with more than sixty people consulted and 150 hours invested. Early results corroborated the basic process steps and potential catalytic impact.

Once all the advocacy meetings were held and the data collected, assessment of the compiled results are shared with those participants and beyond, seeking a shared global consensus and ownership for the follow-up process.

The prayer is that Kingdom initiatives will come forth during the advance phase, under local/regional/global ownership realities given by God for increased church planting and social/cultural changes throughout the world. Through it all, we pray for and seek transformed lives within the body of Christ worldwide, at every level of society and geographical setting across the globe, as pictured in Figure 1.

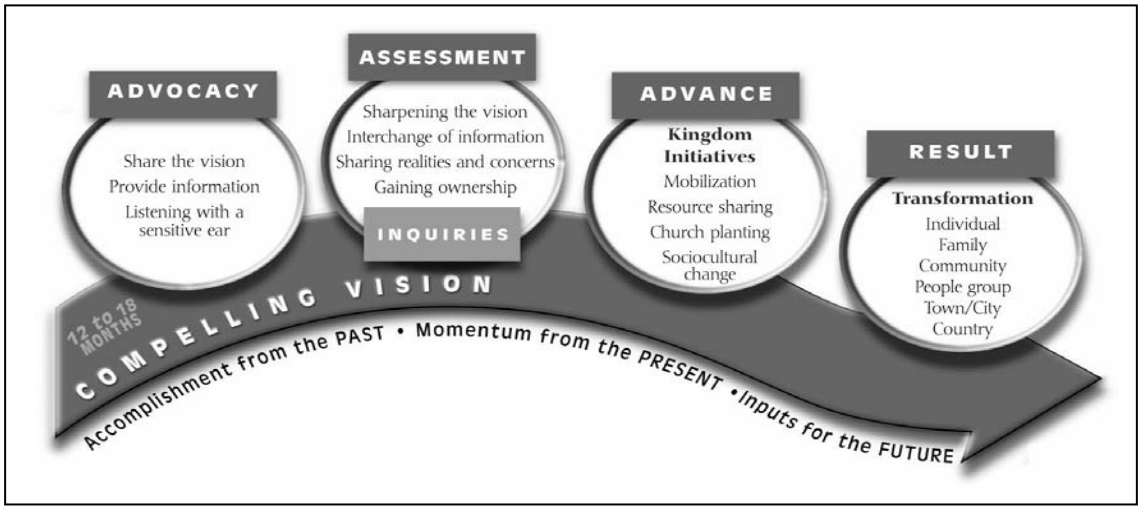


FIGURE 1 INQUIRY PROCESS

5. Because of the Historical Precedence of the William Carey Inquiry in India which Launched the Modern Era of Missions

On the 200th year of the modern era of missions, an article was written on William Carey by the President of the Evangelical Missiological Society. In it he affirms that the Carey Inquiry sparked the launch of a major advance in world evangelization:

In 1992, we stand at the 200th anniversary of two key events that launched Carey into his 40-year missionary career. In 1792 he published *An Inquiry into the Obligations of Christians to Use Means for the Conversion of the Heathen*, and he preached his "deathless sermon" from Isaiah 54:2-3, "Expect great things. Attempt great things" (Beals 1992).

The Carey Inquiry provides a precedent for advancing world evangelization. His Inquiry mobilized thousands of Christians in England and North America for the cause of missions. "[Carey's] little book became the Magna Carta of the Protestant mission movement" (Winter 1997).

6. Because of the Still Unfinished Task of the Evangelization of South Asia

This inquiry among influential and emerging Christian leaders is prompted by the challenge of the unfinished task of evangelization in South Asia recognized by missiologist as the mother of all missiological challenges of our time. Much has been accomplished toward the end even as we celebrate the advance in church planting especially in India in recent times.

This research project will, we pray, help gain the discernment needed for church, mission, and ministry decision-making, by providing local insights into the questions and directions that relate to citywide, national, regional, and global matters related to the unfinished task.

One of the issues facing this question relates to the meaning of "the unfinished task of world evangelization." To aid in the discussion, a description of what the finished task presented may look as follows: The finished task can be summarized as Jesus Christ, incarnate in His Body, the church, in every segment of humanity, showing forth His love, compassion, truth and power as salt and light resulting in a transformed church transforming communities. The Body, being sensitive and insightful into the many social, cultural, linguistic, ethnic, economic distinctives and differences within the populace, would be continually permeating all elements of society both with the Word (light), but also with care, compassion and righteousness (salt) (Bush 2000a).

A list of principles presented at the Amsterdam 2000 Conference regarding the unfinished task serves even now, twenty years later, as one of the resources for focus group discussion.

At the strategy working group gatherings in the conference, further definition of the unfinished task was left as an open issue, yet to be addressed. This inquiry process seeks to reflect on the nature of the unfinished task. This description was presented at the Amsterdam 2000 Conference held from July 29 to August 6, 2000 sponsored by the Billy Graham Evangelistic Association. More than five hundred strategists considered the unfinished task, the obstacles therein and the way forward. The list of principles included the following:

a) The unfinished task involves offering man forgiveness of sin and liberation from sin.

b) Seeking to fulfill the unfinished task involves going forth as an act of loving obedience, a "being sent" by the risen Lord. It demands complete submission to Jesus Christ, constant fellowship with Him, constant devotion to Him, and service to Him.

c) The unfinished task majors in effective communication of the good news of God and in baptizing, teaching, and discipling the believers with the primary emphasis on making disciples.

d) A primary mechanism in fulfilling the unfinished task is the conversion of households, called "ecclesias."

e) The unfinished task involves the conscious entry into the territory of Satan in order to liberate people from satanic power and tyranny. It aims at opening the eyes of the nations and turning them from darkness to light and from the power of Satan to God.

7. Because of the Need to Discover and/or Define the New Paradigms of Mission

There are expressions in the evangelical mission community of a vision gap and silence regarding a cohesive global initiative at the present time: Is it just my imagination, or is the silence beginning to roar? As Paul McKaughan observed following an inquiry in North America which was one of the prompters of the three-year World Inquiry launched in 2001: "Strategies to address the vision are also in short supply in view of mission leaders. The "new paradigms that help us interpret and organize our strategies for the future have not become clear."

One of the questions relates to whether or not there should be a united global strategy of the body of Christ? If so, what are the elements needed for an effective strategy? Should there be a watchword? What about a date in the watchword, which?

8. Because of the Tectonic Changes in the Context of Mission

One of the challenges faced by mission leaders is the accelerating pace of change in in recent years whether demographic, economic, technological, global, political, or social. As Dudley Woodberry once noted: "This leads to uncertainty, information overload, hesitancy to make long-term commitments, and difficulty in making plans".

From the inquiry conducted by McKaughan and others in 1998, "The winds of change are swirling with great intensity around the Christian missionary enterprise. The world is changing radically: economically, politically and religiously." As the mission leaders traveled around the country meeting in different cities, the observations on the current mission scene in the U.S. took on a pattern. It can be summarized by the following statements:

a) When did missions change from being vision-driven to budget-driven?

b) Today's generation does not respond to a command structure, nor to guilt trips.

c) (Mission) headquarters are afraid of decentralization.

d) Most churches are interested in survival, not missions.

e) The U.S. church is compassion depleted.

Conclusion: Now is the time to launch the India Inquiry: ***For Such a Time as This***. Why? Because the conversation issued illuminates the purpose of God in our time; because focus group inquiries are biblical at different seasons; because there is a need to hear intentionally and primarily from Christian leaders in India which can also serve as a model for the rest of South Asia and beyond; because of the catalytic nature of the inquiry process in advancing God's Kingdom purposes; because of the historical precedence of the William Carey Inquiry which launched the modern era of missions; because of the

still unfinished task of World Evangelization; because of the need to discover and/or define the new paradigms of mission and because of the tectonic changes in the context of mission in our world today. We have seen the fruit of the India Inquiry conducted almost twenty years ago in the transform world movement today. We believe we should join hands with God's people everywhere to listen together to what God the Holy Spirit is saying to His church today.